

The 1939 working manuscript: what the edits show, and where they could go

Working note for the Human Author, 12 September 2026. Source: WorkingManuscript_1939.

Every facsimile page of Hazelden's *The Book That Started It All* (2010) was read from the 241 photographs and every change that mattered was checked against the 1939 text already in the corpus (BigBook_1939). Manuscript pages are cited by the number Hazelden prints beside each facsimile ("MS p. 30"). Hazelden's own essays are cited as Hazelden's claims, and anything they quote from AA's copyrighted histories is at a remove. Quotations are kept to the few words needed to identify an edit: this is a map to the pages, not a transcription of them. Early members are named by initial, as elsewhere in the project.

In brief

1. **The edits change who is speaking far more than how firmly.** Across the programme chapters, instruction to "you" becomes a report of what "we" did. The modal usually survives: typed "You must take the lead" became "we found we had to" in pencil and "We must take the lead" in print (MS p. 41). Nowhere does "you must" become "we ought", which is how Chapter 4 describes the change.
2. **The qualifier on God is older than the comment round in one place and younger in two.** "As we understood Him" is typed in Step 3 of the circulated draft. In Step 11 it is written in by hand over a struck "a Power above us" (MS pp. 30-31). And the "Why don't you choose your own conception of God?" episode in Bill's Story is a handwritten insert on two loose leaves, keyed into MS p. 10, that the circulated draft did not contain.
3. **"Group" comes out wherever the text speaks as a body.** "As a group" is struck twice, "Members of our group" once, a hope that "our group" would reform institutions goes with its paragraph, and readers flag Oxford Group vocabulary with "GRP", "Group" and "Too Groupy". At galley stage a "non-denominational group" became "non-denominational people" and a "rule" became a "principle". The one expansion runs the same way: "the Fellowship" became "Fellowships", plural, in each city and hamlet.
4. **The Foreword already held the substance of four Traditions,** typed before any comment came in: anonymity at the public level, not an organization in the conventional sense, no fees or dues, and one requirement for membership. Beside it the draft proposed a central trust whose outside trustees would "always constitute a majority" and whose approval every business engagement would need.
5. **The collective process narrowed at the end.** As many as four hundred copies went out, deliberately to outsiders as well as members, but the comments were collated onto one copy, chiefly in one hand by Hazelden's account, under an author who called himself the umpire, and the last changes were made by four people correcting galleys. One outside reader, the psychiatrist Dr. Howard, is named in the margins on at least eight pages; some of his changes went in and more did not.

6. **Ten of the printed book's thirty stories were not in the circulated draft.** A pencilled list inside the back cover names them in print order. The one story struck through with a withdrawal note was printed anyway, moved from the middle of the sequence to the end.
 7. **Members' own figures put early-1939 meetings between thirty and eighty people.** A consistency check on the model's room of sixty and nothing more.
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The document

What it is. In mid-February 1939 the draft was run off by multilith, a small offset process, and as many as four hundred copies, stamped as loan copies, went to members, doctors, clergy and others. Wilson later said the point was to find anything that "goes against the grain". The comments were written onto one copy, this one, over about six weeks before the final edit.

Hands. Lead, green and red pencil, a little ink. "HGP", Hank P.'s initials by Hazelden's reading, stands at the foot of nearly every text page; the Sotheby's catalogue that Hazelden quotes gives most annotations to him and some to Wilson. Readers are named in the margins: Dr. Howard on MS pp. 10, 11, 18, 19, 23, 46, 56 and 86, a "Dr. Witherspoon" on p. 17 as far as the pencil can be read, and a reader whose name begins "De B" on the Foundation page, who found it anticlimactic. A red note on p. 21 cites "our away gang", which Hazelden reads as the Akron members. Nothing here attributes a hand beyond what the page signs.

Printer's marks. MS p. 1 is marked "1 Printer" and p. 58 "Copy for type setter"; every story page from p. 81 carries "Printer" and its number, in black to p. 126 and in green from p. 127. Hazelden's first essay argues from the near illegibility of p. 43 that this was not the typesetter's copy. The marks suggest that at least the story section was prepared for the typesetter; they leave the heavily edited text pages open.

Three states, not two. For some sentences the draft, the pencil and print all differ. Hazelden's example is MS p. 38, where "You will know you are on the Broad Highway" became "We knew we were" and then, in print, "We feel we are". The galley stage made changes this copy does not record, and some of them put back force the pencil had taken out.

The baseline, and two missing pages. BigBook_1939 is a 1999 reprint. It carries one bracketed editorial note quoting the multilith, and it omits the 1939 appendix on The Alcoholic Foundation, so the manuscript's Foundation page cannot be compared with print from the corpus. Book pages 22 and 23 were not photographed; they are probably the multilith title page and Lois W.'s presentation leaf, both described in Hazelden's essays. The OCR text held beside the PDF is a search aid only.

What the edits change

1. Instruction becomes testimony

The heaviest and most consistent change. Whole paragraphs move from "you" to "we" and from present to past (the Foreword, MS p. 16, and pp. 25 to 44 almost throughout), and three families of phrase go with them.

- **Selling.** "Designed to sell you three pertinent ideas" becomes "make clear" (p. 31); getting "thoroughly sold on the idea" of being a candidate for the fellowship is struck (p. 18); "The kick you will get is tremendous" is struck (p. 45); "Try it" is struck after "It works" (p. 44).

- **The ultimatum.** A reader not yet convinced was told to re-read the book “or else throw it away”; the sentence is circled out (p. 31).
- **Kneeling.** “Get down upon your knees” before the Third Step prayer is struck (p. 32), and “on our knees” leaves Step 7 (p. 30). Wilson’s later gloss, which Hazelden quotes, was that the draft had readers on their knees and needed to stand them up.

The readers said why. “Should be studied from the mold angle” heads How It Works (p. 30); a margin on p. 32 notes that Bill is known as someone who does not want to pour people into moulds; p. 43 has “POURING THE MOLD”; and the endpaper (p. 156) asks why, if organized religion’s fault is pouring people into moulds, the book should give specific instructions at all. The metaphor is the book’s own. *The Unbeliever*, typed in the same draft, complains that the preachers tried “to pour everyone into moulds” (p. 89, and again p. 91). The reviewers turned the text’s complaint against religion back on the text.

What happened to the modal. This is where Chapter 4 needs changing.

- p. 41: typed “You must take the lead” became “we found we had to”; print has “We must take the lead”.
- p. 41: typed “you ought to say” lost its “ought to” in pencil; print has “We feel we ought to say”.
- p. 42: typed “you ought to leave them alone” became “we ought”; print has “we think we ought not to urge them”.
- p. 30: “You must find Him now!” became “May you find Him now!”, the one clear softening of force.

The shift is from command to report, and the galleys put some of the force back in the first person. The manuscript contains no “you must” that became “we ought”.

One edit runs the other way, and the manuscript explains it. In *We Agnostics*, “WHO AM I TO SAY THERE IS NO GOD?” became “are you” (p. 29). The episode being retold is Fitz M.’s, and his own typed story has the voice ask “Who are you to say there is no God?” (p. 106). The change matched the chapter to its source.

Where the second person stayed. Working with Others keeps its “you” (pp. 45 to 51), as Hazelden notes; its reader is already recovered and is being told how to approach somebody else.

2. *God, and whose conception*

- **Step 3** is typed “care and direction of God as we understood Him”. “And direction” is struck; the qualifier stands, underlined, consistent with the italics it is printed in (p. 30).
- **Step 11** is typed “improve our contact with God”. “Conscious” is added, and “as we understand Him” is written in by hand in place of a struck “a Power above us” (p. 31).
- **Steps 1, 6, 7, 8 and 12.** “We” is added before “Admitted”; “willing” becomes “ready”; “on our knees” and “holding nothing back” are struck from Step 7, and “complete” from Step 8’s amends; Step 12 exchanges “this course of action” for “these steps” and drops “others, especially” before “alcoholics”. A pencilled “to our understanding of God” in Step 5, and a query whether “anxious” would show more humility in Step 6, were not taken. Step 12’s “experience” became “awakening” only in the second printing of 1941, per Hazelden.

- **Bill's Story.** The episode in which Ebby T. suggests Wilson choose his own conception of God, with the objection to "a Czar of the Heavens" and the sentence about being willing to believe in a power greater than himself, is written out in pencil on two leaves bound at the front and keyed by "Inst #1" into MS p. 10. There the typed text runs straight from "His roots grasped a new soil" to "Thus was I convinced". Print has the insert. What was already typed matters as much: p. 10 has "as I then understood Him", and We Agnostics has "we mean your own conception of God", untouched (p. 25). The idea was in the draft; its grounding in Wilson's own story was added. A reader on p. 25 suggested moving those We Agnostics paragraphs back into Bill's Story. They stayed where they were, and whether the suggestion prompted the insert cannot be shown.
- **Dr. Howard.** "Word God is a limiting word" heads p. 11, where "God has to work twenty-four hours a day" became "Faith has to work", with a margin asking who we are to say what God has to do. That change went in. Most of his other suggestions to put "faith" for "God" did not (pp. 9, 10), and "Heavenly Father" stayed in Dr Bob's story against "Dr Howard says change" (p. 86).
- **Jim B.'s claim.** Hazelden quotes Jim B.'s later account that his one contribution was qualifying God with "as we understand Him". The typed Step 3 shows the qualifier in the text before the comment round, so whatever he contributed came during drafting, not revision.
- **Fitz M.'s story.** The member Wilson says wanted the more religious book wrote the story with the most open formula in the draft: a power called "God, Allah, Confucius, Prime Cause, Divine Mind, or any other name" (p. 105).

3. *The group comes out of the text*

- "As a group" is struck twice on p. 17, once before "we have no desire to convince anyone" and once from "no concern of ours ... what religious bodies" members belong to.
- "Members of our group have spent thousands of dollars" loses "Members of our group" (p. 37).
- A paragraph on institutions ending in the hope that "our group" would help change them is struck whole (p. 56).
- Readers flag Oxford Group vocabulary: "shared" circled with "GRP" (p. 12), a crossed-out "Group" over Step 3 (p. 30), "Buchman" beside Step 11 (p. 31), "Oxford GROUP" and "This is absolutely Too Groupy" on the Eleventh Step page (p. 43), and two "Group" flags on p. 77.
- At galley stage two more went: "As a non-denominational group, we cannot make up people's minds", typed and unmarked on p. 64, is printed as "non-denominational people"; and "Another rule we observe carefully", typed on p. 61, is printed as "Another principle".
- The one expansion: the hope that "the Fellowship" would spring up became "Fellowships", plural, "in each city and hamlet" (p. 75).

Part of this is shedding the Oxford Group, and the readers say so. The effect is wider: the text stops speaking as a body that holds positions. The draft already said as much in its own typed voice, and those sentences were kept. It does not want to be "the arbiter of anyone's sex conduct" (p. 35); it wishes "to lay down no rule of any sort" (p. 41); it has "no monopoly on God" (p. 48); on serving liquor at home, "We never argue this question" and each family

should decide for itself (p. 51); its suggestions carry “nothing obligatory” (p. 64); the book is by no means the last word (p. 69) and is “meant to be suggestive only” (p. 79). The stories say the same of the gatherings: “nothing organized”, and “fatal to give it any kind of a tag” (p. 90); a meeting “without formality” (p. 121); “none of the crowd were missionaries” (p. 113).

4. *Deference to doctors and clergy*

Mostly Dr. Howard’s, and after the pronouns the largest class of edit, as Hazelden’s own listing also finds. Medical claims are hedged: “is certain to” die becomes “may” (p. 15), and “fatally ill” becomes “very ill”, beside the note “Doctors will shoot” (p. 45). Criticism of psychiatrists goes: “often fruitlessly, we are afraid” (p. 12) and “bitter” (p. 16). A member is armed no longer with “certain medical information” but with “the facts about himself”, after a margin calling doctors “a jealous lot” (p. 12). The paragraph surveying detoxification methods is struck whole after being edited once, so there were two passes (p. 69). “Most doctors” becomes “Many” (p. 23). And “new” is taken out of “something new in the way of a solution” because “Ministers will shoot”, millions having been cured through evangelism (p. 46). This is the manuscript’s clearest precursor of having no opinion on outside issues, and it was argued out margin by margin.

5. *Helping others*

- **The helping claim was defended in editing.** The doctor’s letter said the solution was worked out on the spiritual plane. A reader added “as well as an altruistic” and wrote above it that this frees Wilson from the criticism that he says you cannot get well unless you work with others (p. 2). Print has it.
- **“Helping others is the foundation stone of your recovery”** is pencilled over the typed opening of that sentence (p. 48), and printed.
- **The burden was stated down.** Typed “This sort of thing goes on constantly” became “Occasionally you will have to meet such conditions” (p. 48). The draft already warned that those who shoulder “the entire burden and trouble of others” are soon overcome (p. 64).
- **The motive, typed.** The first members knew they must help others to stay sober, but “that motive became secondary”, transcended by the happiness of giving (p. 77).
- **In the stories.** Dr Bob’s fourth reason, insurance against a slip (p. 86); “he owed me, I didn’t owe him” (p. 90); visiting as “part of the ‘treatment’ ” (p. 95); and a doctor who assigned the calls, asking only that the new man tell his story (p. 144).

6. *Organization and money*

- **The Foreword, typed:** the request that members stay anonymous in public, with the press asked to observe it; not an organization in the conventional sense; no fees or dues; the only requirement an honest desire to stop drinking; allied with no faith and opposing no one. A reader added that any notion of a pat on the back should be separated out, since “the field needs workers”. An offer to send the multilith itself for \$3.50 is struck.
- **A handwritten list of tasks** bound at the front (book p. 26) runs from rewriting the business chapter to “How about Alcoholic Foundation set up?”, and includes chocolate for the craving. That item became the published paragraph citing a doctor who read the book “in manuscript form”, the one place the 1939 book mentions its own comment round. The “Sugar” notes on MS pp. 45, 47, 49 and 65, and “Go back on sugar pages” on p. 59, are its trail through the draft.

- **The Alcoholic Foundation page**, unnumbered, after MS p. 80: a trust to receive inquiries and royalties; three trustees from the fellowship and four from outside, the four and their successors to “always constitute a majority”; “our only agency of its kind”; the trustees’ approval for every business engagement touching the work; and a plan to answer inquiries by referring them to “an active nucleus” in each locality until fellowships spring up there. The proposed centre was small, permanent, controlled from outside, and routed growth through itself. Whether the printed appendix kept all of this cannot be checked from the corpus.
- **Money, at a remove**, from Hazelden’s history and Wilson’s 1954 talk: Works Publishing’s \$25 shares; the Harper advance the Foundation board wanted taken and Wilson and Hank P. turned down; and an Akron meeting of about eighteen that feared the project would “create a professional class” and let Wilson go ahead by a majority of two or three.

7. The stories

- The draft has nineteen stories and a twentieth struck through. The pencilled list inside the back cover adds ten more, with page ranges and the writers’ names (not reproduced here), in the order print gives them: A Close Shave; “Intellectual Agnostic”, printed as Educated Agnostic; Another Prodigal Story; The Car Smasher; Hindsight; On His Way; An Alcoholic’s Wife; An Artist’s Concept; The Rolling Stone; and, as far as the pencil can be read, Lone Endeavor.
- **Ace Full, Seven, Eleven** has a green X through all four of its pages and a note, initialled W.G.W. by Hazelden’s reading, that Del T. thought the book a racket and withdrew it. The manuscript’s page numbering skips it. The 1939 book prints it anyway, as the last story, after Lone Endeavor, rather than after Riding the Rods where the draft had it. The simplest reading is withdrawal during revision and restoration at the very end. The pages cannot say when or why, and the note may postdate either.
- The stories were barely edited. Suggested cuts to The Doctor’s Nightmare, with running word counts of 122 and 219, were not taken (pp. 81-82); a pseudo-medical claim about a foundation’s research was struck from The Unbeliever (p. 88); the opening of Fired Again is boxed with a query (p. 145).
- For Appendix A13. The typed stories’ arrivals are almost all member-carried: through a doctor who was himself a member, a family broker, or a fellow patient, in one case a member who had himself relapsed and was going back to try again (p. 140). The one arrival by book alone, Lone Endeavor, is among the late additions, and its subject was reached with a copy of this multilith. And the line in To Employers that “a great deal can be accomplished by the use of the book alone”, until personal contact is possible, is a pencilled addition that print kept (p. 70).

8. Numbers the text gives

MS page	Where	What members said
11	Bill's Story, Akron	"eighty of us and our families"; gatherings of "40 to 80 persons"
24	We Agnostics	about half the fellowship, "something like fifty of us", once thought themselves atheists or agnostics
78	A Vision for You, Akron	the weekly meeting, "sixty or eighty as a rule"; fifteen members in a town thirty miles away
79	A Vision for You, New York	"thirty or forty"; elsewhere "little clusters of twos and threes and fives"
95	The European Drinker, Akron	"more than seventy persons"
117	Traveler, Editor, Scholar	"some 60" who met once a week
132	My Wife and I, Akron	"some 70 of us"
140-141	Riding the Rods	"some 30 men in my town"; a Wednesday meeting with "some forty others"

These are members' round numbers for overlapping places within a few weeks: not independent observations and not a sample. Their use is the one SMF-132 already has in Chapter 21, a consistency check on the model's room capacity of sixty and not a validation.

What the manuscript cannot tell you

- **Who.** Four or five hands, and only initials and a few names on the page.
- **When.** Annotations are undated. A change's presence shows that someone proposed it, not when or on whose authority, and some notes, Ace Full's perhaps, may be later.
- **Why,** beyond the reasons the margins give.
- **Whether this was the printer's copy.** The marks point both ways.
- **What the printed appendix said.** The corpus's 1939 text lacks it.

Nothing here changes a model value, a cache or a release check.

Suggested uses in the manuscript

In rough order of value. The first, a correction, was made on 13 September 2026: Chapter 4 now says what the pages show. None of the others has been made, and the A13 recount is listed in HANDOFF.md section 10.

1. **Chapter 4, a correction.** Replace "the softening of 'you must' to 'we ought'" with what the pages show: instruction to "you" rewritten as a report of what "we" did, the modal usually kept, and some force restored at galley stage ("We must take the lead"). The rest of that paragraph can now be first-hand for the manuscript layer: some four hundred copies to members and outsiders, collation on one copy, a psychiatrist named in the margins, the kneeling prayer and the ultimatum struck.
2. **Chapter 5, Twelve Points.** The Foreword typed in February 1939 already holds the substance of what became four Traditions, six years before the mail problem the chapter opens with. That sharpens the chapter's account: 1945 and 1946 generalized and codified principles the founders had written down at the start. The same 1939 text proposed

the opposite arrangement for the centre, a permanent board with an outside majority whose approval every business engagement needed.

3. **Chapters 7 and 9, How a Room Decides and Confident and Wrong.** The founding text was not decided by a room. Wide solicitation fed a single collator, an author who called himself the umpire, and four people at the galleys. One outside reader is named on at least eight pages. Akron's group is twice described in its own stories as centred on its doctor, once in so many words as its "human center" (pp. 128, 132). And, at a remove, a title vote in the two groups was set aside, a member recalling that Doc and Bill let everyone fight and then announced the answer. These are Chapter 9's prominent agents in the fellowship's first months, described by members without complaint, and they make a historical foil for the rule the Traditions later wrote. It is an analogy and not a test: a one-pass editorial collation is not repeated averaging.
4. **Chapter 18, Two Kinds of Rule.** The five structural Traditions have 1939 precursors being negotiated on these pages: household autonomy on serving liquor (p. 51), the struck ambition to reform institutions (p. 56), the removal of claims doctors and ministers would contest (pp. 12 to 46), "rule" becoming "principle" at galley stage (p. 61), and set against all of it the Foundation page's central approval. It would let the chapter show that having no hierarchy was chosen against a live alternative written into the founding draft.
5. **Chapter 15, Helping Is Not the Reward.** The "altruistic plane" edit and its stated reason (p. 2), "Helping others is the foundation stone" added in pencil (p. 48), the burden stated down (p. 48), the typed claim that the motive became secondary (p. 77), and the doctor who assigned calls (p. 144). The editors defended the necessity of helping as doctrine while softening its cost, which is close to the chapter's distinction between helping as mechanism and helping as reward.
6. **Chapter 19, You Cannot Close the Door.** The single requirement typed in the Foreword; the open conception strengthened in revision; relapsed members taken back "as though nothing had happened" (p. 122) and by friends who never lectured (p. 128); and Dr Bob's one precondition, whether the man wanted to stop (p. 131).
7. **Chapter 22, What You Cannot Engineer.** The founders' growth plan was to find an active nucleus in each locality and route inquiries to it (the Foundation page); the draft reports small clusters of two to five around two centres (p. 79); and Silkworth wrote in 1939, as Hazelden quotes him, that a community with three or four active members would grow. The chapter's question about founding composition had a 1939 answer in the founders' own heads.
8. **Chapters 24 and 21.** Chapter 24 asks whether dominance scales with room size and says the measurement would be intrusive. The 1939 record describes one room of sixty to eighty centred on one person; it cannot say how that scaled, but it shows the configuration in the fellowship's first rooms. For Chapter 21, the table above is a second consistency check beside SMF-132, eight decades earlier.
9. **Appendix A13.** Three additions and a recount. Ten of the thirty 1939 stories were gathered after the draft circulated, so the census mixes the draft's nineteen with ten late additions and one restored story. The one arrival by book alone, Lone Endeavor, is a late addition whose subject received this multilith. The book-alone line in To Employers was added in pencil, so the fellowship expected the book to work alone as a stopgap even while, in Lone Endeavor's frame, it doubted that. And A13 says twenty-nine stories where

the 1939 contents page in BigBook_1939 lists thirty titles from The Doctor's Nightmare to Ace Full.

Loose ends

- Book pages 22 and 23 are still to be photographed. When they arrive they go through the same cleanup and into the reading copy, which will then have two more pages than photographs listed here.
 - Hazelden's essays quote AA's own histories, chiefly *Alcoholics Anonymous Comes of Age*, *Pass It On* and *Dr. Bob and the Good Oldtimers*. Anything taken from those quotations belongs under "Cited at a remove". The *Comes of Age* passage that HANDOFF.md section 10 still wants, pages 97 to 98, is not among those Hazelden quotes.
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Files

- WorkingManuscript_1939.pdf: the reading copy, one PDF page per photograph in order, searchable through an invisible OCR layer. A copy is in the Human Author's Downloads folder.
- WorkingManuscript_1939.txt: the OCR text with a marker for every page. A search aid only.
- Both are git-ignored and recorded by SHA-256 in metadata.json.